

serve a private room in a restaurant and all pitch in to have it catered, or everybody can simply bring a dish of something over to a member's house for sharing.

Even though you may be well-versed friends, this is a social gathering with a purpose, and that precedent must be set right from the beginning. Formalize the meeting process, and you will be less likely to get off track, both during each meeting, and on the whole.

Here is how the first meeting could look:

- Open the meeting.
- Discuss what investment topics the club wants to focus on, and the format each meeting will have. For example, will you invite knowledgeable guest speakers to present to the club each week, or invite each member to research and discuss a topic, or collectively focus on a certain type of investment or style of investing? Also, are you interested in the same financial topics?
- Query each member as to what they hope to get out of the club.
- Vote on all decisions with a show of hands.
- Elect club officers. This may be unnecessary if you want nothing more than an informal social

gathering, but will be required if you take legal steps to lodge investments together.

- Define each member's responsibilities. When electing club officers this is especially important, but even in an informal setting, saddling everybody with some form of responsibility will increase the club's overall chances of success.
- Set regular meeting times, locations, and miscellaneous details.
- Choose a club name.
- Vote on any necessary decisions with a show of hands.
- Close the meeting.

Subsequent meeting agendas will hinge on the results of the first meeting, and it is equally important that an agenda be set forth for each meeting, and ideally that it remain the same every time. Formalizing a meeting doesn't have to make it dull. It simply keeps things moving and creates a set of expectations that each member can rely on.

This is just enough information to get your club off its feet and into infancy. Where you go from here varies according to the membership, desired outcome, and the format decided upon.

Here are a few Web resources for you to research investment club topics and formats, or even to find an